

permanently in the US. The life of a touring virtuoso was often exhausting and in 1942 he moved to the warm climate of California for the sake of his faltering health. After a concert in Knoxville, Tennessee, in February 1943 he collapsed and had to cancel the rest of his tour. He died of cancer at his Beverly Hills home a month later, a few days before his 70th birthday and a few weeks after becoming a US citizen.

In spite of Rachmaninoff's enormous popularity with the public, contemporary critics were often scornful about the unabashed emotionalism of his music, dismissing it as gushing sentimentality. The entry on him in the 1954 edition of Grove's Dictionary of Music and Musicians predicted that his reputation would not last—a prophecy that has proved entirely misguided, as his place among the titans of music is now unquestioned.